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PUBLIC WEB COMMUNICATIONS

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This instruction implements Air Force Policy Directive (AFPD) 35-1, *Public Affairs Management*. It provides guidance pertaining to integrating new public Internet, Web, and related information technologies into U.S. Air Force public and internal communication programs. It also supports Department of Defense (DOD) 5500.7-R, *Joint Ethics Regulation*. Read this instruction with Joint Publication 3-61, *Doctrine for Public Affairs in Joint Operations,* and AFI 33-129, *Web Management and Internet Use*. This AFI requires the collection and maintenance of personal information including the following systems notices: F035 AF AFNEWS A (Hometown News Release Background Data File), F035 AF SAFPA C (Official Biographies), and F035 SAFPA B (Mobilization Augmentee Training Folders). Records Disposition. Ensure that all records created as a result of processes prescribed in this publication are maintained in accordance with Air Force Manual (AFMAN) 33-363, Management of Records, and disposed of in accordance with Air Force Records Information Management System (AFRIMS) Records Disposition Schedule (RDS) located at **https://www.my.af.mil/gcss-af61a/afrims/afrims**/. Refer recommended changes and questions about this publication to the Office of Primary Responsibility (OPR) using the AF Form 847, *Recommendation for Change of Publication*, and route AF Form 847s from the field through the appropriate functional chain of

command. This instruction applies to the Air Force Reserve Command (AFRC) and the Air National Guard (ANG) unless otherwise noted.

(USAFA) Air Force Instruction (AFI) 35-107, Public Web Communications, 21 October 2009, is supplemented as follows: This supplement covers interaction between the USAF Academy Public Affairs Office (HQ USAFA/PA) and the Directorate of Athletics' Information and Communication Office (USAFA/ADI) and the relationship between the two offices. HQ USAFA/PA handles interaction involving the cadet area and issues while USAFA/ADI handles all intercollegiate sports-related issues as it relates to website communications. USAFA/ADI works closely with HQ USAFA/PA to ensure standards within the base are followed. This publication applies to all United States Air Force Academy (USAFA) personnel. It does not apply to Air Force Reserve Command (AFRC) units and Air National Guard (ANG) units. Refer recommended changes and questions about this publication to the Office of Primary Responsibility (OPR) using AF Form 847, Recommendation for Change of Publication. Ensure that all records created as a result of processes prescribed in this publication are maintained in accordance with AFMAN 33-363, Management of Records, and are disposed of in accordance with the Air Force Records Information Management System (AFRIMS) Records Disposition Schedule (RDS) located at **https://www.my.af.mil/gcss-af61a/afrims/afrims**/.

1. Purpose. This instruction outlines the guidelines for integrating new public Internet, Web, and related information technologies into Air Force public and internal communication programs. This chapter complements other Air Force and Defense documents relating to the use of the Internet and information technology in public and internal communication strategies. It also outlines the roles and responsibilities of the Air Force Public Web Program.

2. Overview. All Air Force public Web sites will be consolidated and centrally hosted as part of the Air Force Public Web Program. This service-wide initiative saves the Air Force money, manpower, and resources while providing a standardized corporate image and content approval process for all Web sites.

3. Roles and Responsibilities.

3.1. Secretary of the Air Force, Office of Public Affairs (SAF/PA) will:

3.1.1. Develop guidance for the integration of public Web sites into the Air Force Public Web Program. Serve as chair of the Air Force Public Web Policy Board.

3.1.2. Develop guidance governing the public communication program and the security and policy review program.

3.1.3. Review and approve/disapprove waiver requests for AF public Web sites hosted outside the scope of the Air Force Public Web Program.

3.2. Air Force Public Affairs Agency (AFPAA) will:

3.2.1. Manage and operate the Air Force Public Web Program and quality assurance program. This includes operational and financial planning and implementation of the program as well as developing and enhancing the content management system.

3.2.2. Set agenda, compile issues, and track submissions for the Air Force Public Web Policy Board. Ensure policy board convenes annually, at a minimum, to recommend updates to policy and guide development efforts for the Air Force Public Web Program.

3.2.3. Manage and operate Air Force Link, **http://www.af.mil**/, the official Web site of the Air Force.

3.3. MAJCOM/FOA/DRU commanders or their designated representatives will:

3.3.1. Ensure conformity with the Air Force Public Web Program.

3.3.2. Identify and designate, in writing, an Air Force Public Web Program representative (group and site managers). An electronic e-mail to the AFPW Program will suffice. Group and site managers will be Public Affairs members (AFSCs 3NXXX, 35PX or civilian equivalent) to the maximum extent possible.

3.3.3. Establish and maintain one official public Web site, specifically structured for general public use.

3.3.4. Ensure relevant public Web sites receive initial security and policy review for content and a usability evaluation by PA staff prior to site launch. Establish record of review and approval for all subordinate content. Additionally, PA must assess the need, requirement, and suitability for release of information.

3.3.5. Provide Air Force Public Web Program standards of content, quality, and appearance for all public Web sites, including those at subordinate organizations when applicable.

3.3.6. Ensure security and policy review of all substantial updates or new material posted to the publicly accessible Web site. Subsequent reviews are necessary to ensure new or updated content meets all security considerations.

3.3.7. Ensure Web sites are registered by submitting the signed memorandum of understanding, provided during the initial migration process to Air Force Public Web.

3.4. Installation-level or equivalent commanders or their designated representatives will:

3.4. **(USAFA)** When publishing Air Force sports on the Web, the Director for Internet Management (USAFA/ADIH) is responsible for updating and maintaining the World Wide Web internet-based athletic home page for athletics.

3.4.1. Ensure conformity with the Air Force Public Web Program.

3.4.2. Initiate and sign/approve appointment letters for the installation's site manager, content manager, and content provider. Identify and designate, in writing, an Air Force Public Web Program representative (site manager). An electronic e-mail to the AFPW Program will suffice. An electronic e-mail from the unit commander, or designated representative, to an individual may constitute an appointment letter. Site managers will be Public Affairs members (AFSC 3NXXX, 35PX or civilian equivalent) to the maximum extent possible.

3.4.3. Establish and maintain one official public Web site, specifically structured for general public use.

3.4.4. Ensure public Web sites receive initial security and policy review for content and a usability evaluation by PA staff prior to site launch. Establish record of review and approval for all subordinate content. Additionally, PA must assess the need, requirement, and suitability for release of information.

3.4.5. Provide Air Force Public Web Program standards of content, quality, and appearance for the public Web site.

3.4.6. Ensure security and policy review of all substantial updates or new material posted to the publicly accessible Web site. Subsequent reviews are necessary to ensure new or updated content meets all security considerations.

3.4.7. Ensure Web sites are registered by submitting the signed memorandum of understanding provided during the initial migration process to Air Force Public Web.

4. Web Site Management.

4.1. Public Web Sites. Public Web sites exist as part of the Air Force's public communication program. Public Web sites will not contain any classification or markings such as ―Approved for Public."

4.2. Approval to Establish Public Web Content. Commanders with the authority to make public the release of information (typically wing- or installation-equivalent commanders) have the authority to approve public Web content. Organizations seeking to publish public Web content will justify that the content is intended for a wide public audience (not military-specific) and coordinate with local PA, legal if appropriate, and communications authorities prior to seeking release approval from the commander.

4.3. Internal Air Force Audience. Web content that targets the internal Air Force audience, and/or requires restricted access controls, should be posted on the Air Force Portal Web site and not the publicly accessible Web site covered under this AFI.

4.4. Web sites hosted outside scope of the Air Force Public Web Program. These sites include specialty sites that require unique consideration because they do not meet criteria established within this publication for authorized public Web sites. Waiver requests and justification must be submitted through the appropriate chain of command to the Air Force Public Affairs Agency (AFPAA) for consideration.

4.5. Web Site Registration. Organizations must ensure their public Web sites are registered as part of the Air Force Public Web Program. To register, an organization must submit the signed memorandum of understanding provided during the initial migration process via fax or e-mail to the Air Force Public Web Division.

4.6. Security and Policy Review. See AFI 35-102, *Security and Policy Review*.

5. Web Site Content.

5.1. General Content. The average Air Force public Web site allows commanders to keep the general public informed of local news and information. Only information cleared for public release in accordance with AFI 33-129, this instruction, and other associated policies and instructions can be posted to public Web sites. The following provides guidance on routine Web content items:

5.1.1. Electronic Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) Reading Room Material. Frequently requested material released as a part of the unit's FOIA program may be posted to the Web site.

5.1.2. Base or Unit Fact Sheet. Maintained locally, base fact sheets provide general history, organization, and economic impact of a particular unit or installation.

5.1.3. Links to Key Leaders. Official biographies of general officers, civilian equivalents, and key senior enlisted personnel are maintained in the Air Force Link Library. Biographies, whether posted to the Air Force Link or the installation's Web site, must not reveal names, addresses or other identifying material of family members of Air Force employees or members.

5.1.4. Links to Associated Weapons Systems. Fact Sheets maintained within the Air Force Link Library provide basic information on aircraft and other weapons systems in the Air Force inventory.

5.1.5. News Releases. Locally produced news, cleared for public release, tell the unit's story.

5.1.6. News Related Photos. Approved local photography of people and associated equipment helps tell the unit's story.

5.1.7. Detailed Imagery. Do not include maps or aerial photography of installations on public Web sites.

5.1.8. Standard Publications and Forms. Standard publications and forms that are not exempt from release under FOIA may be made available through a link to the Air Force's e-Publishing Web site, **http://www.e-publishing.af.mil**/, or via the Air Force Portal.

5.1.9. Links to Higher Headquarters Sites. Sites must link to public sites belonging to higher headquarters within their organizational chain.

5.1.10. Mandatory Links: To promote recruiting and retention, each Air Force components' Public Web site must contain a link to their respective recruiting sites (Active – **http://www.airforce.com**/; Reserve – **http://www.afreserve.com**/; Air National Guard – **http://www.goang.com**/). All components must link to the Air Force Portal at **http://www.my.af.mil**/.

5.2. External Links.

5.2.1. Criteria. The ability to hyperlink to external sources is a fundamental part of the Worldwide Web and can add significant value to the functionality of a public Web site. Air Force activities will establish objective and supportable criteria or guidelines for the selection and maintenance of links to external Web pages. Guidelines must consider the informational needs of personnel and their families, mission-related needs, and public communication and community relations objectives. Such guidelines must be consistent with the following considerations:

5.2.2. Links to non-DOD Web site resources must support the organization's mission. External links must be reviewed periodically to ensure their continued suitability. If the content of a linked external site becomes questionable or objectionable, remove the link.

5.2.3. In accordance with DOD 5500.7-R, *Joint Ethics Regulation*, no product endorsements or preferential treatment shall be given on Air Force public Web sites.

5.2.4. No payment of any kind shall be accepted in exchange for a link placed on an organization's public Web site.

5.2.5. In accordance with DOD 5500.7-R, Air Force public Web sites shall not require or encourage users to choose any specific browser software. Only text or hyperlinked text shall be used to direct visitors to software download sites. Graphics or logos depicting companies or products shall not appear on publicly accessible DOD Web sites.

5.2.6. Organizations will not use ~~"fr~~ames" technology.

5.2.7. Organizations are encouraged to link to authorized activities in support of the organization's mission, such as the Army and Air Force Exchange Service, the Navy Exchange Service Command, and the Marine Corps Exchange. If these sites contain commercial advertisements or sponsorships, the appropriate disclaimer shall be displayed.

5.2.8. To avoid the perception of Air Force promotion or endorsement, links to commercial organizations such as, but not limited to, contractors who produce Web sites, non-military content providers, or event organizers and promoters, must be avoided. If a link to a non-government Web site is considered for placement on an Air Force public site, the commander is responsible for ensuring that a proper disclaimer notice is displayed (see 5.2.11. for an example). The disclaimer must state that neither the Air Force nor the unit endorses the product(s) or organizational entity at the hyperlink destination. The disclaimer must also state that the Air Force does not exercise any responsibility or oversight of the content at destination.

5.2.9. A link from an Air Force public Web site must relate to the mission of the organization. For example, if members of an organization routinely interact with a defense contractor, it is permissible to point to that contractor's Web site. The link must not go to the primary home page, but specifically to the page that directly relates to official Air Force contracted business.

5.2.10. Organizations must realize once a decision is made to link to a non-DOD Web site, the unit may be required to link to similar sites. Any appearance of impropriety may be avoided with a notice identifying similar sources. The notice must state that links to these sources do not constitute official or unofficial endorsement of goods or services by the Air Force and the organization and that the list of sources is not necessarily all inclusive.

5.2.11. Disclaimer for External Links. The disclaimer below shall be displayed when linking to external sites. This disclaimer may appear on the page or pages listing external links or through an intermediate "exit notice" page generated by the system whenever a request is made for any site other than an official DOD Web site (usually the .mil domain). An example of such an exit notice is: "The appearance of hyperlinks does not constitute endorsement by the (organizational name), the United States Air Force, or the Department of Defense of the external Web site, or the information, products, or services contained therein. For other than authorized activities such as military exchanges and Services/Morale, Welfare and Recreation (MWR) sites, the United States Air Force does not exercise any editorial control over the information you may find at these locations. Such links are provided consistent with the stated purpose of the Web site."

5.3. Links to Restricted Sites. Air Force public Web sites will not link to restricted sites which are unavailable or inaccessible to the general public.

5.4. Posting of Base Newspapers on the Internet. While the publishing of base newspapers constitutes public release of information, the distribution is normally limited. Web sites constitute a much broader, global release of information to the general public. Therefore, some information appropriate for printed base newspapers may not be appropriate for publicly-accessible Air Force Web sites. The content of base newspapers may be reproduced for the Web site if that content meets the restrictions provided in DOD's *Interim Policy, Web Site Administration Policies and Procedures* (25 Nov 1998). All stories must be reviewed against Part V of the DOD policy prior to being posted to public Web sites.

5.5. Point of Contact (POC). Point of contact for each significant Web page is required. Use generic or organizational POC information, not individual e-mail addresses.

5.6. Feedback. Each site must provide a means to provide feedback or request further information.

5.7. Current as of Date. Information posted on Web site must be kept current.

6. Usability Requirements: Section 508.

6.1. In 1998, Congress amended the U.S. Rehabilitation Act of 1973 to require that federal agencies make their electronic and information technology accessible to people with disabilities. Section 508, 1194.22, *Web-based Intranet and Internet Information and Applications*, is of particular importance with regard to Web site management. This section outlines the requirements for federal Web sites, both Internet and intranet. It states that federal Web sites must meet the needs of disabled employees and members of the public and allow them access to Internet technology in a format understood by software readers/viewers. In order to accomplish this, several simple, fundamental changes are required. For the entire list of requirements, go to **http://www.section508.gov**.

7. Inappropriate Material and Prohibitions.

7.1. The following items are inappropriate for public Web sites:

7.1.1. Inappropriate Links. Air Force public Web sites will not link to offensive or unrelated commercial material.

7.1.2. Operational and Personnel Security. Air Force public Web sites will not post references to any information that would reveal sensitive movements of military assets or personnel or the locations of units, installations, or personnel where uncertainty is an element of security of a military plan or program.

7.1.3. Personal Information. Use of personal information protected by the Privacy Act (AFI 33-332, *Privacy Act Program*) is prohibited. Further restrictions on the use of personal information are provided by DOD policy, *Web Site Administration Policies and Procedures*, 25 Nov 1998.

7.1.4. Copyright Information. Copyrighted material may only be used with written permission from the owner (see AFI 51-303, *Intellectual Property—Patents, Patent Related Matters, Trademarks and Copyrights*). United States laws on copyright, primarily 17 U.S.C. 101, et seq., preserve, for the owner of copyrighted material, the benefits and earnings to be derived from the reproduction and distribution of such works. Material that is subject to copyright protection includes ~~"o~~original works of authorship fixed in any tangible medium…," 17 U.S.C. 102(a). It is now accepted that computer software, sequences of code, and instructions, are in fact subject to copyright.

7.1.5. Trademarks and Logos. The use of commercial trademarks or logos is prohibited.

7.1.6. Inactive or broken links. Inactive or broken links must be corrected or removed immediately.

7.1.7. ~~"U~~Under Construction" Notices. These notices will not be used.

7.1.8. All content on a public Web site must be cleared for public release. Do not include material that is classified or for official use only. Public Web sites will not contain any classification markings. Do not include scientific and technical information that has not been cleared for public release.

8. Appearance. The appearance of public Web sites will be standardized through the Air Force Public Web Program. Only designs and templates approved by the Air Force Public Web Program management team will be used. Exceptions to this policy must be approved by AFPAA prior to public access.

9. Collection of Information. Air Force Web sites must comply with DOD limitations on the collection and use of user information. The use of cookies or other browser measures to gather information on public site users beyond statistical summaries is prohibited. Web site administrators will ensure the appropriate privacy and security notices are included or linked to the home page.

10. Web-based Message Boards, Threaded Chat Rooms, and Guest Books. These technologies allow users to post opinions, messages, or information openly on a Web site. They provide a useful means of creating two-way communication but are prohibited as part of public Web site services.

11. Information Collection, Records, and Forms.

11.1. Information Collections. No information collections are created by this publication.

11.2. Records. The program records created as a result of the processes prescribed in this publication are maintained in accordance with AFMAN 33-363 and disposed of in accordance with the AFRIMS RDS located at **https://afrims.amc.af.mil/rds_series.cfm**.

11.3. Forms (Adopted and Prescribed).

11.3.1. Adopted Forms. AF Form 847, *Recommendation for Change of Publication*.

11.3.2. Prescribed Forms. No forms are prescribed by this publication.

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Attachment 1

GLOSSARY OF REFERENCES AND SUPPORTING INFORMATION

References

Title 17, *United States Code – Copyrights*, October 2007

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AFMAN 33-363, *Management of Records*, 1 Mar 2008

AFRIMS RDS, **https://afrims.amc.af.mil/rds_series.cfm**

Abbreviations and Acronyms

AFI—Air Force instruction

AFPD—Air Force policy directive

DOD—Department of Defense

DODD—Department of Defense directive

DODI—Department of Defense instruction

DRU—direct reporting unit

FOA—field operating agency

FOIA—Freedom of Information Act

MAJCOM—major command

OASD/PA—Office of the Assistant Secretary of Defense for Public Affairs

PA—Public Affairs

PAO—Public Affairs Office, Public Affairs officer

POC—point of contact

SAF—Secretary of the Air Force